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Nurturing sustainability: the interplay among digital marketing communication, online customer experience and sustainable purchase intention

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Abstract

Purpose – This study aims to delve into the underlying factors that play a pivotal role in shaping effective digital marketing communication (DMC) to promote sustainability. Further, it explores the mediating effect of online customer experience (OCE) on the dynamic relationship between DMC and sustainable purchase intention (SPI) and the moderating impact of social media marketing activities (SMMAs) on the relationship between DMC and OCE.

Design/methodology/approach – Based on single cross-sectional survey, 300 responses from green apparel users are analyzed by using partial least squares-structural equation modeling to corroborate the relationships among DMC, OCE, SMMAs and SPI.

Findings – Perceived usefulness, ease of use, web attractiveness, hedonic motivation and subjective norms significantly impact DMC, which in turn positively influences OCE and SPI. Further, OCE significantly mediates the relationship between DMC and SPI, highlighting the crucial role of OCE. The moderation analysis shows that interactivity negatively moderates the DMC-OCE relationship, suggesting that excessive interactivity may diminish the OCE, while personalization and trendiness do not have significant moderating effects.

Practical implications – The findings provide valuable insights for marketers to align their DMC strategies with sustainable business initiatives to create a seamless online experience, thereby fostering SPI in the contemporary digital era.

Originality/value – While previous studies have examined aspects of these relationships separately, this study integrates them into a cohesive framework to provide a more holistic understanding of how digital marketing strategies can promote sustainability.

Keywords Digital marketing communication, Online customer experience, Sustainable purchase intention, Social media marketing activities, Green apparel

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

In the contemporary digital age, the internet has transformed the realm of marketing communication, thereby fundamentally altering the ways in which organizations engage with their target audience. This paradigm shift has ushered in a new era of possibilities for businesses to foster meaningful interactions with their clientele. The domain of digital marketing communication (DMC) has experienced a notable surge within the broader discipline of marketing. Recognizing the imperative of harnessing technological advancements to stay

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competitive in the dynamic landscape, companies are progressively shifting their focus toward DMC (Selem *et al.*, 2023). Need of effective DMC is evidenced by statistics from Hubspot (2013), indicating that 45% people ignore direct mail, while 85% actively skip through television commercials, and 84% exhibit a tendency to swiftly navigate away from websites overloaded with advertisements. DMC strategies have the capacity to yield a noteworthy 54% increase in lead generation than traditional marketing communication. Organizations may harness the power of DMC by integrating digital and social media platforms as an integral component within their overall corporate marketing frameworks.

Sustainability has garnered significant attention of marketers, practitioners and academics in recent years (Nekmahmud *et al.*, 2022). The burgeoning fashion sector has become a focal point of concern due to its adverse environmental effects. Fashion production contributes 10% to the total carbon emissions generated by human activities, leading to depletion and contamination of water sources (UNEC, 2018). Only a small fraction of population opts for recycled clothing. Given the concerning levels of pollution caused by the apparel industry, it becomes crucial to engage in educating consumers through DMC regarding the enduring impact of their apparel purchasing choices on the environment. When consumers are well-informed about the long-term repercussions of their buying habits, they are more likely to integrate sustainability in their decision-making process (Nekmahmud *et al.*, 2022).

The present study aims to delve into the realm of consumer attitude toward DMC, with a specific focus on elucidating how marketers can effectively harness the power of DMC to enhance the online customer experience (OCE). The study seeks to analyze the underlying mechanisms through which the strategic implementation of DMC can nurture sustainable purchase intention (SPI) among consumers. Additionally, an examination of the mediating impact of OCE to drive SPI and the moderating role the social media marketing activities (SMMAs) may play in influencing the relationship between DMC and OCE are also contemplated within the purview of this comprehensive investigation.

2. Theoretical background and research hypothesis

2.1 Privacy calculus theory

Privacy calculus is a cognitive and psychological mechanism through which individuals assess the potential trade-offs between negative repercussions and advantageous gains that may arise from disclosing personal information (Kordzadeh *et al.*, 2016). Individuals engage in a rational evaluation of privacy-related decisions through the lens of economic considerations (Hu *et al.*, 2020).

Privacy concern (Dahmani and Ben Youssef, 2023) and intrusive concern (Wottrich *et al.*, 2018) are the main components of the privacy calculus theory. A substantial increase in financial fraud can potentially evoke concerns related to privacy among users (Krishen *et al.*, 2019). Consumers are more likely to perceive information disclosure as being unjust when privacy risks are relatively high, despite recognizing the benefits of disclosure (Liu *et al.*, 2018). Similarly, the intrusiveness of advertisements affects how consumers perceive marketing communication (Wottrich *et al.*, 2018). Intrusive concern and privacy concerns have a negative effect on consumer perceptions of visiting online sites and their tendency to make a purchase on social networking sites (SNS) (Wottrich *et al.*, 2018):

$H_1 1$. Privacy concerns have a significant negative impact on DMC.

$H_1 2$. Intrusive concerns have a significant negative impact on DMC.

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2.2 Unified Theory of Acceptance and Technology 2 model

Venkatesh *et al.* (2012) introduced the Unified Theory of Acceptance and Technology 2 (UTAUT2) as an extension of UTAUT that analyzes and explains the technology adoption process. Performance expectancy, effort expectancy, social influence and facilitating condition are the major four constructs of UTAUT. UTAUT2 additionally includes hedonic motivation, price value and habits of consumers (Venkatesh *et al.*, 2012). When studying the impact of DMC on consumer attitudes, it is crucial to capture both the intrinsic and extrinsic motivators influencing user behavior.

Hedonic motivation emerges as potent predictor of the inclination to engage with digital platforms (Fülöp *et al.*, 2023). Mishra *et al.* (2022) underscored the significant impact of social influence on shaping behavioral intention to use digital platforms. Social influence is intrinsically connected to the concept of subjective norms (Luna and Pennock, 2018). Empirical investigations have consistently demonstrated the positive influence of social influence and hedonic motivation on attitudes toward digital platforms (Gharaibeh *et al.*, 2020):

$H_1$3. Hedonic motivation has a significant positive impact on DMC.

$H_1$4. Subjective norms have a significant positive impact on DMC.

2.3 Elaboration likelihood model

The dual routes (central and peripheral) of the elaboration likelihood model (ELM) elucidate the reception and processing of a message and emphasize the subsequent attitude changes of an individual (Petty and Cacioppo, 1986). The peripheral route represents a cognitive process that occurs when an individual lacks motivation or cognitive capacity to engage deeply with a message, instead of relying on heuristic cues influenced by emotions and visual appeal (Shahab *et al.*, 2021). Central route is at the opposite end of continuum, where individuals engage in thorough and reasoned processing of information (Petty and Cacioppo, 1984).

Argument quality is a key construct influencing central route processing (Kuo, 2024; Liang and Lin, 2018), denoting the persuasiveness of message (Bhattacherjee and Sanford, 2006). Higher level of argument quality exerts a positive impact on perceived acceptability of the content being presented (Selem *et al.*, 2023; Kim *et al.*, 2016) by cultivating trust among consumers (Petty and Cacioppo, 1984; Shahab *et al.*, 2021). Brand posts that contain convincing arguments develop robust customer attitude toward brand (Vo *et al.*, 2024). This heightened level of engagement through persuasive arguments fosters the utility of information (Kuo, 2024) and forms a favorable attitude toward the digital platform.

Previous research endeavors have also delved into multiple facets of web attractiveness (peripheral route), encompassing elements such as color palettes, typography choices, page structures, visual elements and textual formats (Liang and Lin, 2018). Web attractiveness and user experience (UX)/user interface (UI) are interconnected as they collectively contribute to the effectiveness of DMC strategies. Web attractiveness focuses on the visual and aesthetic appeal of a platform (Jongmans *et al.*, 2022), which serves as the first point of engagement for users. On the other hand, UX/UI emphasizes usability, functionality and intuitive design, ensuring that the platform meets user needs seamlessly (Hasan *et al.*, 2024). By combining both elements, marketers can create engaging and efficient digital interfaces that enhance user satisfaction and retention (Jongmans *et al.*, 2022; Hasan *et al.*, 2024). Thus, a high level of perceived web attractiveness and argument quality fosters a positive attitude toward DMC:

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$H_1 5$. Web attractiveness has a significant positive effect on DMC.

$H_1 6$. Argument quality has a significant positive effect on DMC.

2.4 Technology acceptance model

The technology acceptance model (TAM), developed by Davis (1989), was designed to predict the likelihood of an individual or organization adopting a new technology. The model identifies two critical factors: perceived usefulness (PU), which is the belief that technology will enhance work performance, and perceived ease of use (PEOU), which is the belief that technology will require minimal effort (Davis, 1989).

PU not only plays a pivotal role in shaping consumers attitudes toward online shopping activities (Nguyen *et al.*, 2024) but also exerts a significant influence on usage patterns, levels of satisfaction and overall performance (Davis, 1989). Li *et al.* (2021) explored the acceptance of e-learning platforms among university students, demonstrating a positive relationship between PU and their intention to use the platform. Kim and Ko (2012) evaluate PEOU pertaining to social networking platforms, highlighting the significant impact of user-friendly interfaces and functionalities on users' perceptions within digital settings. Sharma and Madan (2022) examined the acceptance of e-commerce platforms in India, revealing that both PEoU and PU significantly influenced users' attitudes:

$H_1 7$. Perceived usefulness has a significant positive effect on DMC.

$H_1 8$. Perceived ease of use has a significant positive effect on DMC.

2.5 Digital marketing communication and online customer experience

OCE relates to how customers perceive their interactions with commerce websites, as compared to their experiences with traditional stores (Purani and Sahadev, 2008). Williams *et al.* (2020) emphasize the interplay between tone and substance of online messages, elucidating how these elements possess remarkable capacity to shape consumer emotions. Jaiswal and Singh (2020) underscored the critical importance of integrating diverse DMC channels as a means to enhance coherence and consistency of OCE. Effective communication strategies, active engagement with online content and adept interactions with consumers constitute pivotal determinants that wield a substantial influence on the quality of OCE (Tsimonis and Dimitriadis, 2014):

$H_1 9$. DMC has a significant positive effect on OCE.

2.6 Moderating role of social media marketing activities

Zhang *et al.* (2014) emphasize that SMMAs shape seamless experiences for consumers by increasing consumer engagement and product visibility. These platforms provide interactive environment where companies may directly connect with their audience in real time (Selem *et al.*, 2023; Nekmahmud *et al.*, 2022). The interactive nature of DMC enables consumers to easily access diverse array of information, such as product reviews, recommendations and sustainability initiatives. In addition, SMMAs allow brands to get vital knowledge about customers' preferences and habits, enabling the implementation of more focused and efficient marketing strategies in digital environment (Stephen and Lamberton, 2016):

$H_1 10$ SMMAs moderate the relationship between DMC and OCE.

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2.7 Digital marketing communication and sustainable purchase intention

Shukla *et al.* (2023) showed that an environmental message via digital platforms makes customers more likely to buy eco-friendly products. Chi *et al.* (2021) validate the relationship between exposure to positive environmental content on a company's website and consumers' inclination to choose ecological products. DMC exhibits culturally distinctive effects on purchase intention, with varying interpretations across regions leading to diverse outcomes (Bright and Daugherty, 2012), particularly in the promotion of clothing brands (Raza and Zaman, 2021). Wang and Sun (2010) found that Romanians perceive online advertising as more informative and credible than the Chinese, yet the Chinese counterparts exhibit a higher purchase likelihood. Similarly, Durvasula *et al.* (2001) revealed cross-cultural differences in advertising beliefs, underscoring the diverse cultural interpretations of advertising's role and impact globally. Leveraging digital channels for the dissemination of green messages not only shapes consumer attitudes positively but also plays a crucial role in enhancing their willingness to engage in sustainable consumption practices and make eco-conscious purchase decisions (Bocken *et al.*, 2019):

$H_1 11$. DMC has a significant positive effect on SPI.

2.8 Online customer experience and sustainable purchase intention

OCE involves the interactions between consumers and online shopping environment that contribute to a subjective experience (Trevinal and Stenger, 2014). OCE positively impacts various metrics, including satisfaction, trust and purchase and repurchase intention (García *et al.*, 2018). Recognizing the importance of consumers' experiences in online environment is crucial for service providers aiming to maintain successful businesses (Liu *et al.*, 2018). Effortless and enjoyable online shopping journey enhances consumers' confidence and contentment, thereby influencing their inclination towards SPI (Liang and Turban, 2011):

$H_1 12$. OCE has significant positive impact on SPI.

2.9 Mediating role of online customer experience

An effectively managed online platform not only streamlines the shopping process but also increases consumers' awareness of sustainable products. This heightened awareness is instrumental in shaping their purchasing decisions, leading to a greater intention to buy sustainable products (Liang and Lin, 2018). Liang and Turban (2011) posit that positive UX fosters a more profound sense of reliability and gratification toward online platforms, which, in turn, influences consumers' propensity to adopt sustainable practices. Consequently, the interplay between an enjoyable shopping experience and effective online platform management (Awan *et al.*, 2022) is pivotal in driving the transition toward more sustainable practices:

$H_1 13$. OCE mediates the relationship between DMC and SPI.

2.10 Research gap

Previous studies have explored various facets of privacy concerns (Dahmani and Ben Youssef, 2023), web attractiveness (Jongmans *et al.*, 2022), advertising intrusiveness (Wottrich *et al.*, 2018) and hedonic motivation (Fülöp *et al.*, 2023). However, there is a notable gap in research integrating these factors within the context of DMC and OCE. While existing research acknowledges the influence of online platforms on purchase intention

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(Liu *et al.*, 2018), there is limited investigation into how these platforms facilitate sustainable practices in online shopping.

The UTAUT2 model (Mishra *et al.*, 2022; Dahmani and Ben Youssef, 2023), ELM (Shahab *et al.*, 2021), PCT (Dahmani and Ben Youssef, 2023) and TAM (Li *et al.*, 2021) have all been extensively used in the studies. Nonetheless, an integrated framework combining these theories to examine DMC remains scarce. Furthermore, there is a dearth of extensive research that comprehensively examines the relationship between DMC, OCE, SPI and SMMAs. The present study aims to address these gaps, providing a holistic analysis that integrates these theoretical perspectives to better understand their collective impact on DMC and to corroborate the relationship among DMC, OCE, SPI and SMMAs as shown in Figure 1.

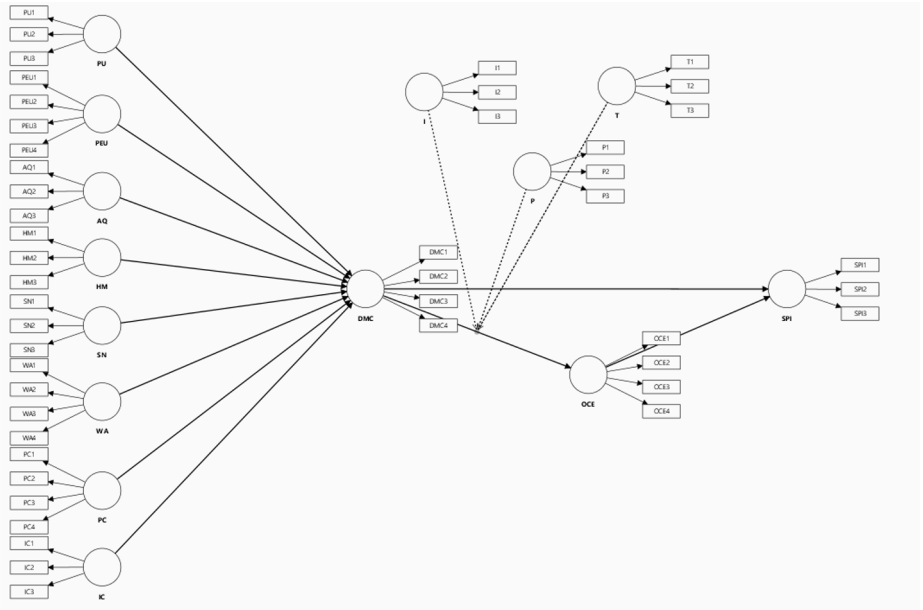
2.11 Research objectives

- to identify various antecedents of DMC;
- to measure the impact of DMC on OCE and SPI;
- to investigate the mediating role of OCE on the relationship between DMC and SPI; and
- to examine the moderating impact of SMMAs on the relationship between DMC and OCE.

3. Research methodology

3.1 Research design and sampling technique

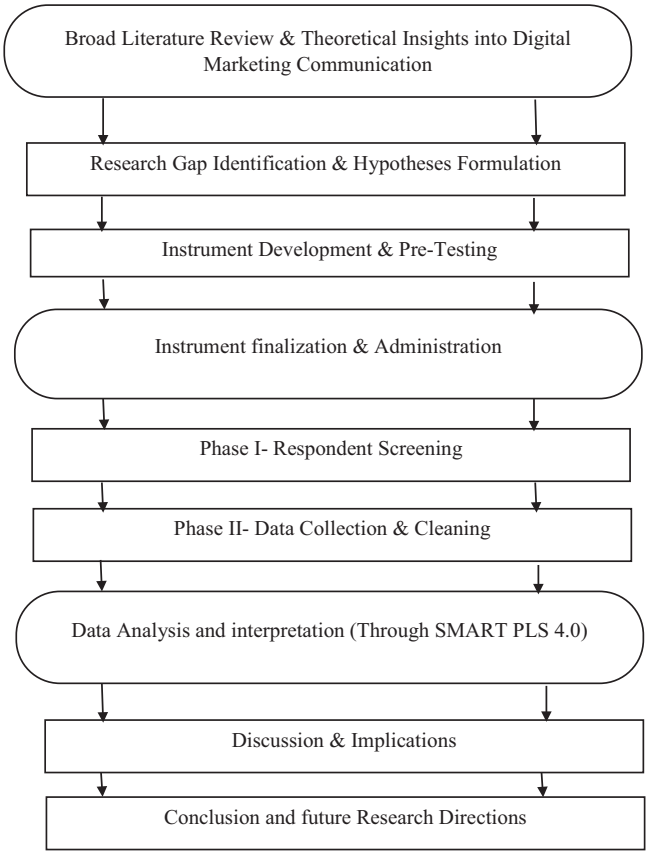
The present study incorporates both exploratory and descriptive research designs to conduct a comprehensive examination (Figure 2). Based on single cross-sectional survey, primary



Source: Authors' own work

Figure 1. Conceptual framework

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Source: Authors' own work

Figure 2. Study execution process

data is collected from young green apparel customers of North India by using a judgment sampling technique. The young customers oriented toward green apparel buying are increasingly aware of the detrimental effects of fast fashion on the environment and seek alternatives that promote recycling, water conservation and the reduction of harmful chemicals, such customers are environmentally conscious individuals who prioritize sustainability in their purchasing decisions. Environmental consciousness of youth (Prakash *et al.*, 2018) and their significant spending on clothing and fashion products (Kautish *et al.*, 2019) make this segment suitable for the study.

Previous studies on green apparel in Northern India (Khare and Kautish, 2021; Kautish *et al.*, 2019) focused on areas like Noida, Gurgaon, Delhi and Ghaziabad. Expanding the scope, a self-administered questionnaire was distributed to university students from multiple academic disciplines of institutions located across Delhi, Punjab and Haryana, representing a diverse sample of different states of North India. Prioritizing university students for the

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present studies draws its inspiration from previous work (Nittala, 2014), emphasizing the strong impact of education on consumers' awareness level and their response to green marketing initiatives.

The study was conducted in two phases: 323 respondents having knowledge of green apparel and DMC (scrutinized in Phase I) were approached for final responses in Phase II. After data screening and cleaning, the effective sample size was 300.

3.2 Instrument design

For data collection, a well-structured instrument was adopted. The study uses a seven-point Likert scale (1 = "Strongly Disagree" and 7 = "Strongly Agree") to collect the responses. The measurement items – argument quality (Bhattacherjee and Sanford, 2006; Chang *et al.*, 2015), web attractiveness (Liang and Lin, 2018; Wakefield *et al.*, 2011), privacy concerns (Krishen *et al.*, 2019), intrusive concern (Espinoza and Juvonen, 2011), hedonic motivation (Liu and Li, 2011), subjective norms (Rejón-Guardia *et al.*, 2020), PU (Nguyen *et al.*, 2024), PEoU (Sharma and Madan, 2022), attitude toward DMC (Bailey *et al.*, 2018), OCE (Chen *et al.*, 2004) and SPI (Liang and Lin, 2018; Trevinal and Stenger, 2014) – are adapted from previous literature (Appendix) according to suitability of the study. After ensuring face and content validity, a pre-testing phase was conducted. Subsequently, after incorporating necessary modifications, the final instrument was distributed for data collection.

Further, partial least squares structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) was used to corroborate the relationships among DMC, OCE, SMMAs and SPI with the assistance of SmartPLS 4.0 software.

4. Data analysis and interpretation

4.1 Common method bias test

The study uses Harman's single-factor test to evaluate common method bias (CMB). An unrotated factor analysis was performed on the constructs to assess CMB. The analysis revealed that the variance explained by the first factor was below threshold (30%), indicating no significant impact of CMB (Harman, 1976).

According to Table 1, the demographic distribution of the sample population is as follows: out of 300 respondents, 133 (44.3%) are female and 167 (55.7%) are male. Further, majority of participants (81.3%) frequently use social media platforms, 16.7% respondents report limited social media usage and a small fraction, six respondents (2.0%) are least active on social media.

4.2 Measurement model evaluation

4.2.1 Convergent validity. Cronbach's alpha was used to verify the reliability. All constructs exhibited Cronbach's alpha values exceeding 0.70 (Table 2), indicating no issues with reliability. Convergent validity was assessed using composite reliability (CR), standardized factor loading and average variance extracted (AVE). CR ranges from 0.880–0.959 (Table 2), all surpassing the 0.70 threshold value, suggesting strong reliability. AVE values exceed the ideal 0.50 threshold (Hair *et al.*, 2014). The item loadings surpass the optimum value of 0.70 (Hair *et al.*, 2014), with CR exceeding 0.70, indicating strong convergent validity.

4.2.2 Discriminant validity. The heterotrait-monotrait ratio of correlations (HTMT) is used to assess discriminant validity among constructs. HTMT values should be below 0.85 for distinct constructs. Table 3 confirms that constructs are distinct from each other, supporting discriminant validity of the measurement model.

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Table 1. Demographic details of the respondents (n = 300)

Demographics	Frequency	%
Gender		
Male	167	55.7
Female	133	44.3
Average age	22	
Education qualification		
Undergraduate	77	25.7
Graduation/diploma	30	10
Post-graduation	192	64
Professional	1	0.3
Social media usage		
High social media usage	244	81.3
Medium social media usage	50	16.7
Low social media usage	6	2
Marital status		
Unmarried	298	99.3
Married	2	0.7

Source: Authors' own work

4.3 Structural model

Table 4 and Figure 3 illustrate the results of hypothesis testing for the relationship among antecedents and DMC, OCE and SPI.

4.3.1 Hypothesis testing. $H_1 1$: Privacy concerns negatively impact DMC with a path value of –0.044, but this relationship is not significant (p-value = 0.268). Thus, the hypothesis is rejected, indicating that privacy concerns do not have substantial effect on DMC.

$H_1 2$: The path from intrusive concern to DMC shows negative and insignificant effect (path value = –0.014, p-value = 0.798), leading to hypothesis rejection.

$H_1 3$: Hedonic motivation significantly influences DMC with a path value of 0.142 and a p-value of 0.007. This accepted hypothesis emphasizes that enjoyment and excitement derived from digital platforms enhance DMC.

$H_1 4$: Subjective norms have a significant effect on DMC (path value = 0.228, p-value < 0.001). This underscores the influence of social factors on consumer attitude toward DMC.

$H_1 5$: The relationship between web attractiveness and DMC is significant, with a path value of 0.106 and a p-value of 0.032. This supports the hypothesis that visually appealing digital marketing content positively impacts customers attitude toward DMC.

$H_1 6$: Argument quality to DMC has a path value (β) of 0.040 and insignificant p-value of 0.240, leading to the rejection of the hypothesis, indicating that argument quality does not significantly influence DMC.

$H_1 7$: Perceived usefulness significantly affects DMC, with a path value of 0.292 and p-value < 0.001, highlighting the pivotal role of usefulness for effective DMC.

$H_1 8$: PEoU has a significant positive impact on DMC (path value = 0.264, p-value < 0.001), highlighting that user-friendly digital platforms are essential for effective DMC.

$H_1 9$: DMC significantly influences OCE with a path value of 0.419 and p-value < 0.001. This indicates that effective DMC is crucial for enhancing the overall customer experience.

$H_1 11$: Finally, DMC has a significant and robust impact on SPI, with a path value of 0.483 and p-value < 0.001, confirming that effective DMC directly enhances consumers' intention to make sustainable purchases.

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Table 2. Convergent validity and reliability analysis

Construct	Items	Loading	Cronbach's alpha	Rho_a	Composite reliability	AVE
Perceived usefulness	PU1	0.857	0.81	0.81	0.88	0.72
	PU2	0.851				
	PU3	0.847				
Perceived ease of use	PEU1	0.887	0.85	0.87	0.90	0.70
	PEU2	0.883				
	PEU3	0.820				
	PEU4	0.758				
Argument quality	AQ1	0.881	0.85	0.88	0.90	0.76
	AQ2	0.922				
	AQ3	0.826				
Hedonic motivation	HM1	0.854	0.81	0.82	0.89	0.73
	HM2	0.852				
	HM3	0.862				
Subjective norms	SN1	0.875	0.84	0.84	0.90	0.76
	SN2	0.859				
	SN3	0.885				
Web attractiveness	WA1	0.866	0.90	0.91	0.93	0.78
	WA2	0.899				
	WA3	0.881				
	WA4	0.898				
Privacy concerns	PC1	0.958	0.97	1.16	0.97	0.91
	PC2	0.983				
	PC3	0.932				
	PC4	0.941				
Intrusive concerns	IC1	0.901	0.89	0.90	0.93	0.82
	IC2	0.902				
	IC3	0.919				
Digital marketing communication	DMC1	0.870	0.89	0.89	0.92	0.75
	DMC2	0.850				
	DMC3	0.853				
	DMC4	0.898				
Trendiness	T1	0.961	0.95	0.99	0.97	0.91
	T2	0.962				
	T3	0.950				
Interactivity	I1	0.924	0.90	0.95	0.93	0.83
	I2	0.895				
	I3	0.916				
Personalization	P1	0.948	0.93	1.02	0.95	0.87
	P2	0.923				
	P3	0.940				
Online customer experience	OCE1	0.899	0.90	0.90	0.93	0.76
	OCE2	0.891				
	OCE3	0.869				
	OCE4	0.848				
Sustainable purchase intention	SPI1	0.902	0.82	0.84	0.89	0.74
	SPI2	0.821				
	SPI3	0.860				

Source: Authors' own work

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Table 3. Discriminant validity

	AQ	DMC	HM	I	IC	OCE	P	PC	PEU	PU	SN	SPI	T	WA	I*DMC	P*DMC	T*DMC
AQ																	
DMC	0.30																
HM	0.26	0.71															
I	0.55	0.31	0.21														
IC	0.20	0.51	0.69	0.22													
OCE	0.34	0.73	0.68	0.35	0.55												
P	0.39	0.09	0.05	0.47	0.02	0.13											
PC	0.21	0.03	0.07	0.21	0.02	0.04	0.10										
PEU	0.21	0.71	0.64	0.26	0.50	0.61	0.05	0.04									
PU	0.37	0.76	0.62	0.41	0.46	0.70	0.24	0.04	0.53								
SN	0.22	0.69	0.63	0.20	0.52	0.55	0.08	0.09	0.54	0.58							
SPI	0.29	0.74	0.64	0.33	0.46	0.65	0.13	0.03	0.63	0.66	0.60						
T	0.35	0.15	0.13	0.43	0.02	0.08	0.40	0.53	0.09	0.17	0.18	0.13					
WA	0.18	0.58	0.63	0.27	0.49	0.61	0.07	0.04	0.49	0.53	0.44	0.50	0.06				
I*DMC	0.39	0.60	0.58	0.37	0.44	0.69	0.15	0.10	0.50	0.60	0.55	0.62	0.14	0.53			
P*DMC	0.41	0.42	0.47	0.27	0.36	0.46	0.05	0.14	0.38	0.46	0.41	0.50	0.15	0.37	0.68		
T*DMC	0.35	0.40	0.43	0.30	0.32	0.47	0.18	0.13	0.37	0.45	0.42	0.47	0.12	0.37	0.72	0.79	

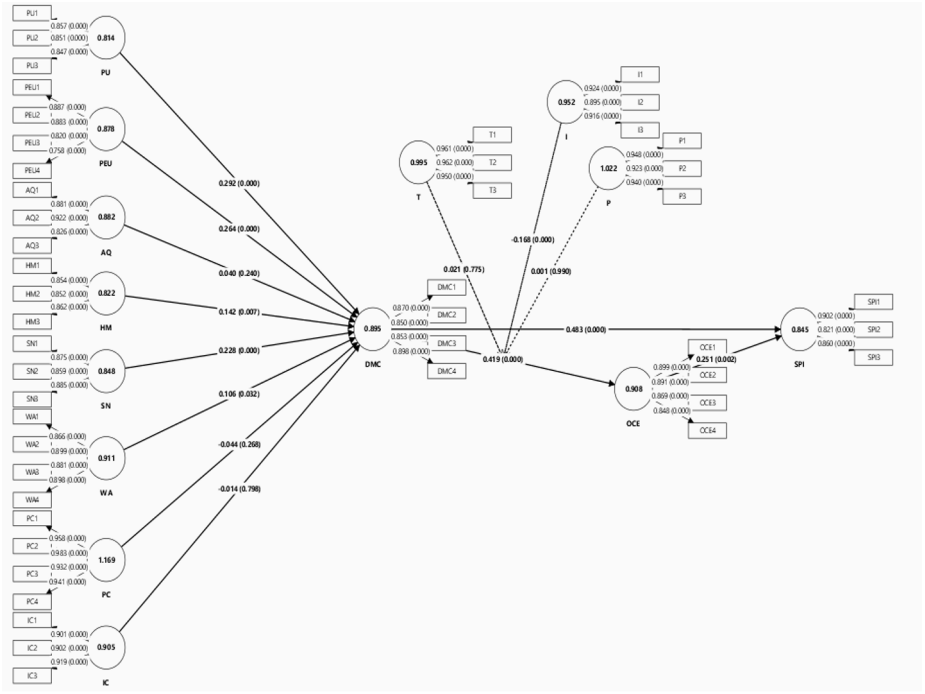
Source: Authors' own work

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Table 4. Path analysis

	Hypotheses	Path value	Sig	Result
PC → DMC	*H1*	−0.044	0.268	Rejected
IC → DMC	*H2*	−0.014	0.798	Rejected
HM → DMC	*H3*	0.142	0.007	Accepted
SN → DMC	*H4*	0.228	0.000	Accepted
WA → DMC	*H5*	0.106	0.032	Accepted
AQ → DMC	*H6*	0.040	0.240	Rejected
PU → DMC	*H7*	0.292	0.000	Accepted
PEU → DMC	*H8*	0.264	0.000	Accepted
DMC → OCE	*H9*	0.419	0.000	Accepted
DMC → SPI	*H11*	0.483	0.000	Accepted
OCE → SPI	*H11*	0.251	0.002	Accepted

Source: Authors' own work



Source: Authors' own work

Figure 3. Path analysis

$H_1$12: The path from OCE to SPI is significant (path value = 0.251, *p*-value = 0.002), supporting the hypothesis that a positive OCE fosters SPI.

4.3.1.1 Mediation analysis. *$H_1$13*: Table 5 reveals the significant mediating role of OCE in the relationship between DMC and SPI. The total indirect effect of DMC on SPI through

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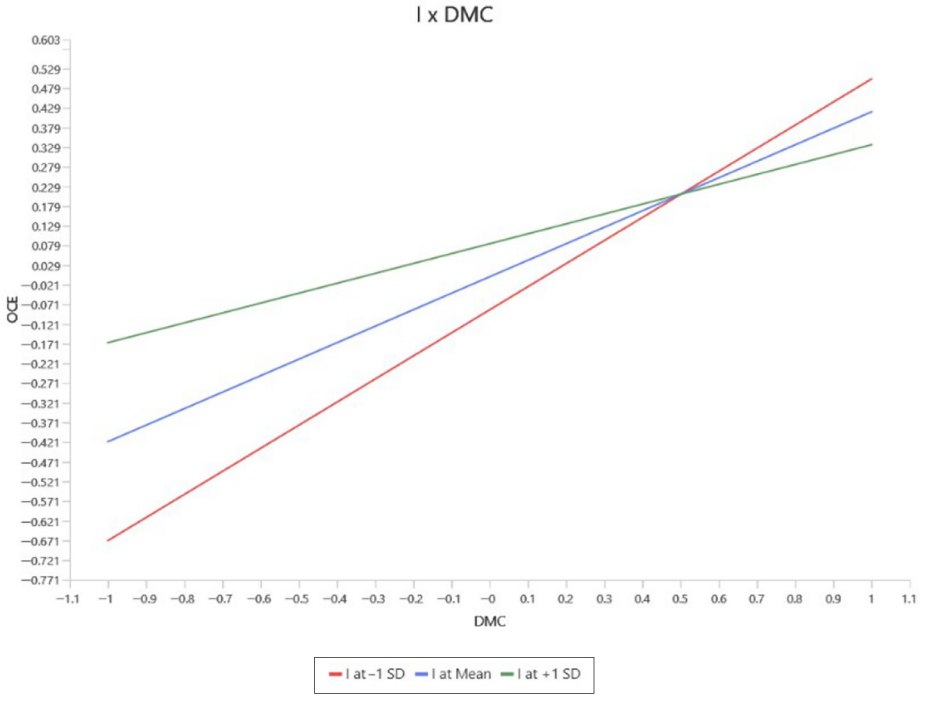
Table 5. Mediation analysis

Path	Coefficient	*p*-value
Direct path		
DMC → SPI	0.48	0.00
Indirect path		
DMC → OCE	0.42	0.00
OCE → SPI	0.25	0.00
DMC → OCE → SPI (total indirect effect)	0.11	0.00
Total effect		
DMC → SPI (total)	0.59	0.00

Source: Authors' own work

OCE is significant, with a coefficient of 0.11 (*p*-value = 0.00). This signifies that OCE partially mediates the relationship between DMC and SPI. Further, the total effect of DMC on SPI is also significant with a coefficient of 0.59 (*p*-value = 0.00). This demonstrates that DMC exerts a considerable influence on SPI, both directly and indirectly through OCE.

4.3.1.2 Moderation analysis. $H_1 10$: The negative path value (–0.168) and significant *p*-value (0.00) indicate that higher interactivity negatively moderates the relationship between DMC and OCE (Figure 4). The insignificant *p*-value of personalization and



Source: Authors' own work

Figure 4. Moderating effect of interactivity

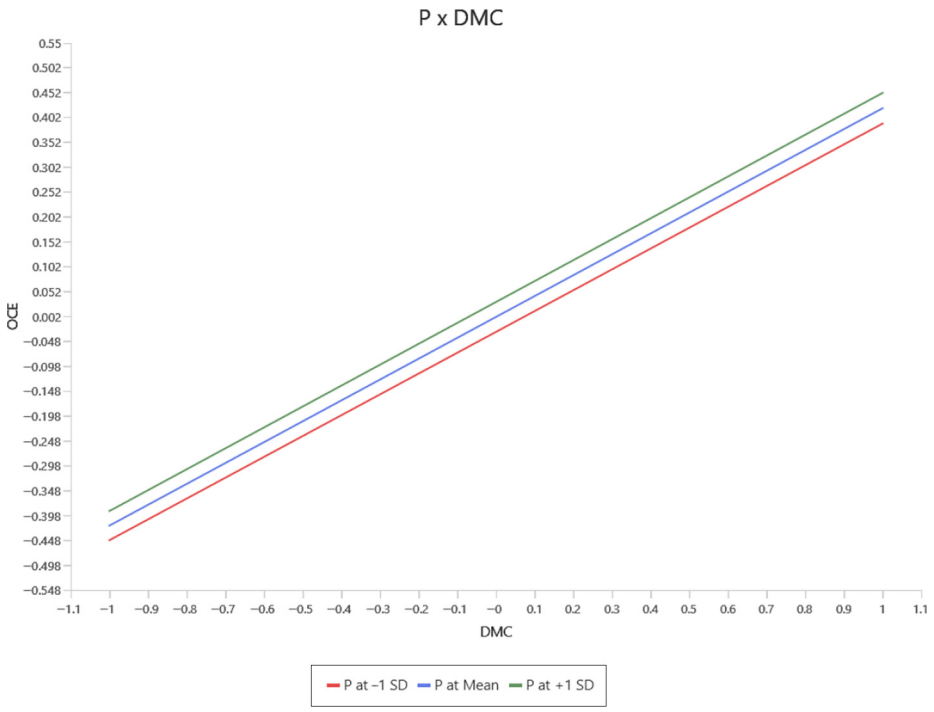
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trendiness in Figures 5 and 6 (0.990 and 0.775 respectively) reveal that both do not significantly moderate the relationship between DMC and OCE (Table 6).

5. Discussion

The observed positive impact of PU and PEoU affirms that customers are more likely to engage with digital content when they perceive them as useful and user-friendly (Nguyen *et al.*, 2024). The positive impact of subjective norms, web attractiveness and hedonic motivation on DMC also aligns with prior research (Gharaibeh *et al.*, 2020).

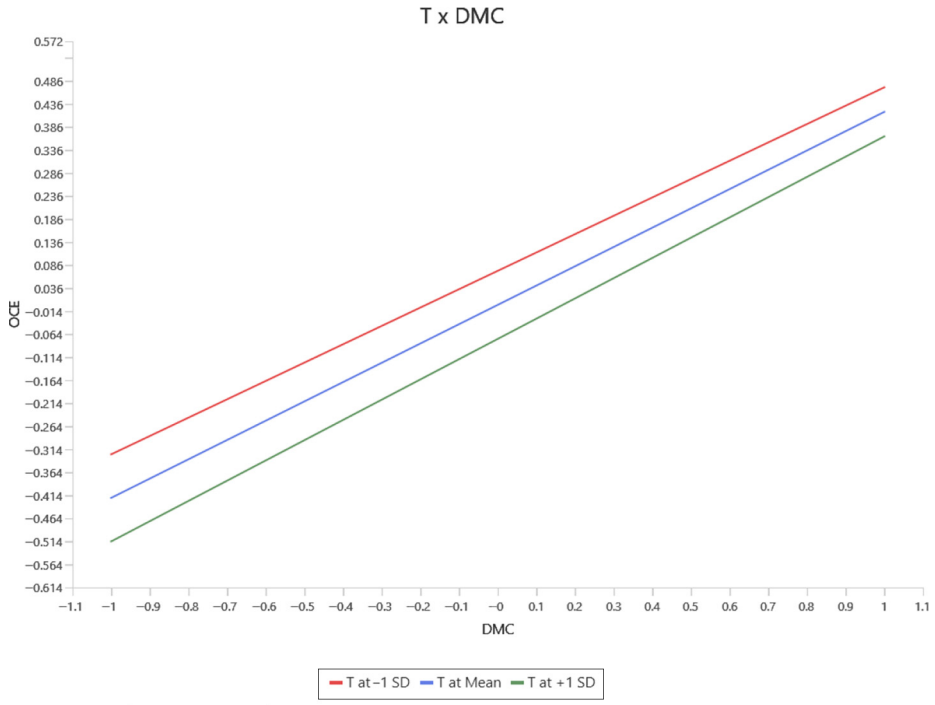
Surprisingly, contrary to the past studies (Bhattacherjee and Sanford, 2006; Selem *et al.*, 2023), argument quality, privacy concerns and intrusive concerns are found to have insignificant impact on DMC. Although privacy concerns and intrusive concerns affect DMC negatively, insignificant results show that customers do prioritize factors such as content relevance and emotional appeal over these factors. Customers' trust in the brand or platform, displaying the advertisement, may mitigate concerns related to privacy or intrusiveness. The significant impact of DMC on OCE and SPI indicates that engaging and persuasive digital content can enhance the OCE and positively influence SPI (Bocken *et al.*, 2019). Significant mediating role of OCE highlights its importance in enhancing the impact of DMC on SPI. Effective DMC not only directly boosts SPI but also does so indirectly by improving OCE. Negative moderating impact of interactivity indicates that high level of interactivity might lead to information overload, distractions or complexity, thereby reducing



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Figure 5. Moderating effect of personalization

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Figure 6. Moderating effect of trendiness

Table 6. Moderation analysis (social media marketing activities)

	Hypotheses	Path value	Sig	Result
I × DMC → OCE	*H10a*	−0.168	0.000	Partially accepted
P × DMC → OCE	*H10b*	0.001	0.990	Rejected
T × DMC → OCE	*H10c*	0.021	0.775	Rejected

Source: Authors' own work

the positive impact of DMC on OCE. Personalization and trendiness were found to be insignificant moderators, suggesting that their effects on DMC-OCE relationship are minimal or non-existent. Overall, these findings provide actionable insights for digital marketers and business strategists for effective DMC in enhancing OCEs.

6. Theoretical and managerial implications

The present study has several theoretical implications for comprehending DMC in a holistic way. The integration of ELM, UTAUT2, TAM and PCT in the study contributes significantly to the existing marketing literature in several ways. By synthesizing multiple established theoretical frameworks, the study allows researchers and practitioners to explore the underlying

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mechanisms that influence customers' attitudes in digital realm. Each of these theories brings its unique perspectives, thereby enhancing the predictive accuracy of marketing outcomes.

The integrated framework not only advances theoretical knowledge but also offers practical guidance. The aesthetic appeal of digital marketing content plays a crucial role in influencing customer attitudes. Managers should invest in high-quality visuals, engaging layouts and aesthetically pleasing designs for their digital platforms. Managers may incorporate engaging content into their digital marketing strategies, such as gamified content, interactive polls and entertaining videos. Critical role of social factors suggests that encouraging satisfied customers to share their experiences and reviews can create a community of advocates who positively impact others' perceptions. A significant impact of PEoU advocates that digital marketing efforts should provide clear, practical and valuable information that meets customer needs. Managers should prioritize the usability of their digital interfaces. This involves designing intuitive navigation, minimizing the steps required to complete actions and ensuring that content is easily accessible across various devices and platforms. Employing professional web designers and UX/UI experts may help marketers enhance the attractiveness and usability of DMC. Though the insignificant impact of privacy concerns reflects weak consumers' sensitivity toward privacy risks, managers need to prioritize robust data protection measures and transparently communicate these efforts to sustain consumer trust. Intrusive marketing tactics do not significantly deter DMC according to this study. Despite this, managers should avoid overly intrusive strategies, but they can afford to experiment with varied marketing frequencies and methods to find a balance that maintains engagement without crossing into intrusiveness.

Effective DMC is crucial for enhancing both the OCE and SPI. By delivering engaging, relevant and valuable content, brands can foster positive customer experiences and drive SPI. Negative moderating effect of interactivity suggests that overly interactive elements might overwhelm or frustrate users, detracting from their overall experience, so managers should carefully balance interactive features. While personalization and trendiness factors are valuable, they may not drastically alter the impact of DMC on OCE. Managers should still strive to personalize content and stay trendy but focus more on the core elements of DMC that directly influence customer experience.

7. Conclusion

The present study elucidates the key drivers of effective DMC and its broader implications for consumer behavior and sustainability. These insights are crucial for developing targeted, impactful digital marketing strategies that not only engage consumers but also promote SPI. The findings emphasize the need for an integrated approach that combines aesthetic appeal, entertainment, social influence, utility and user-friendliness to maximize the impact of DMC.

The present study is constrained to adopt cross-sectional design to capture consumer attitudes toward DMC at a single point of time. Researchers may conduct longitudinal studies to assess how consumer attitudes evolve over time in response to sustained digital marketing efforts. The future scope of the study lies in investigating the impact of artificial intelligence (AI), augmented reality (AR) and virtual reality (VR) on DMC to understand their potential to further enhance OCE and SPI. The focus of present study was confined to the impact of DMC on OCE and SPI due to time and resource constraints, thereby permitting little scope for examining cultural and regional impacts. Research may be expanded to include cross-cultural analysis, examining how cultural and geographical differences influence the effectiveness of DMC strategies. Considering the synergistic effects that emerge from DMC integration with diverse social media platforms, it would be interesting to examine how different platforms interact to foster consumer engagement, brand loyalty and purchase behavior.

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Appendix

Table A1. Measurement items

Item code	Statements	
PU1	The information regarding sustainable apparel on digital platforms is very useful	(Nguyen *et al.*, 2024)
PU2	The digital promotional messages make my life easier before purchasing green apparel	
PU3	I frequently find plenty of digital information related to sustainable apparel	
PEoU1	Learning about digital marketing message is easy for me	(Sharma and Madan, 2022)
PEoU2	Digital information about sustainable apparel through digital platforms is clear and understandable	
PEoU3	It is easy to discover digital marketing messages	
PEoU4	I find digital sustainable messages very useful for shopping	
AQ1	The product information on digital platform is informative	(Chang *et al.*, 2015)
AQ2	Digital marketing communication is valuable	
AQ3	Marketing content on digital platforms is helpful	
HM1	I enjoy exploring sustainable apparel options on digital platforms	(Liu and Li, 2011)
HM2	The marketing messages on digital platforms are entertaining	
HM3	Using digital media for purchasing green apparel is exciting	
SN1	People who influence my behavior think that I should use digital platforms for sustainable messages	(Rejón-Guardia *et al.*, 2020)
SN2	The people important to me believe that I should prefer digital platforms for green apparel	
SN3	My family and friends suggest that following eco-friendly apparel on digital platforms is a good idea	
WA	Digital marketing communication is:	(Wakefield *et al.*, 2011)
WA1	Very attractive	
WA2	Classy	
WA3	Elegant	
WA4	Beautiful	
PC1	I feel that data stored on digital platforms may be stolen by hackers	(Krishen *et al.*, 2019)
PC2	My financial/personal information may get compromised once submitted on digital platform	
PC3	While using digital platforms, I am anxious that others may identify my activities	
PC4	I am concerned that data stored on digital platforms may be used for other purposes	
IC1	I believe the promotional information provided on digital platforms is intrusive	(Espinoza and Juvonen, 2011)
IC2	I feel online marketing content to be irritating	
IC3	I think promotional messages on digital platforms to be interfering	
DMC1	I have a favorable attitude toward digital marketing messages regarding green apparel	(Bailey *et al.*, 2018)
DMC2	I like online marketing messages related to sustainable apparel	
DMC3	I pay attention to digital promotional information before purchasing sustainable apparel	
DMC4	I usually prefer digital marketing information to buying eco-friendly clothes	
T1	Social media content of green apparel brand is latest	(Kim and Ko, 2012)
T2	Using sustainable brands' social media is really trendy	
T3	It is a leading fashion to use green apparel brand's social media	

(*continued*)

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Table A1. Continued

Item code	Statements	
I1	Sustainable apparel brands' social media facilitates two-way interaction	
I2	It allows to share and update the existing content	
I3	It is easy to share my opinion through social media of the green apparel brand	
P1	Green apparel brands' social media facilitates personalized information search	
P2	Sustainable apparel brands' social media provides customized service	
P3	I feel my needs are met by using sustainable apparel brands' social media	
OCE1	My overall experience on digital platforms of green apparel is memorable	(Chen *et al.*, 2004)
OCE2	Concentration level is an important prerequisite while using digital platforms	
OCE3	Digital platforms of green apparel provide me immersive experience	
OCE4	I experience complete engagement of my mind while using digital platforms	
SPI1	I am planning to buy sustainable apparel in the future	(Liang and Lin, 2018)
SPI2	I plan to buy sustainable apparel regularly	
SPI3	I will expend more effort on sustainable apparel in comparison to traditional apparel	

Source: Adapted from previous studies

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